Why are rising food prices hard to control?

GS III

- **Food inflation** occurs when the prices of essential food items rise over time. Poorer households spend a larger share of their income on food, making price increases particularly burdensome. Rural families can face additional pressure when rising food expenses combine with uncertain agricultural earnings.
- Food prices depend on agricultural production, weather conditions and **market supply**. Excessive rainfall, crop damage and changing climatic conditions can reduce the availability of vegetables and other crops. When supply falls while demand remains strong, consumers may face higher prices.
- Food inflation can spread beyond individual commodities through transportation, processing and distribution costs. Higher fuel prices and disruptions in **supply chains** can make food more expensive. Such pressures may persist even when monetary authorities attempt to reduce overall demand through higher interest rates.
- Controlling food inflation requires measures that address both immediate shortages and underlying supply problems. Better storage, efficient transportation, improved **agricultural productivity** and stable distribution systems can reduce price pressures. Monetary policy can support inflation control but cannot directly restore damaged crops or increase harvests.

Food inflation places heavy pressure on vulnerable households. Lasting price stability requires stronger agricultural supply systems alongside monetary measures that manage wider inflationary pressures.

Why is firecracker pollution difficult to control?

GS III

- Firecrackers release smoke, gases and **fine particles** into the atmosphere during combustion. These emissions can worsen air quality, particularly when pollution from vehicles, construction and other sources is already high. Weather conditions that restrict pollutant dispersal can intensify the resulting pollution.
- **Green crackers** are designed to reduce certain emissions compared with conventional fireworks. However, reduced emissions do not mean pollution-free celebrations. When large numbers of crackers are used together, their combined emissions can still contribute significantly to deteriorating air quality.
- Environmental regulations become ineffective when restrictions are not **consistently enforced**. Illegal manufacturing, unregistered sellers and difficulty distinguishing approved products from conventional fireworks can weaken compliance. Effective regulation therefore requires reliable product identification, market monitoring and accountability throughout the supply chain.
- Air pollution control requires action across **multiple sources** rather than relying only on seasonal firecracker restrictions. Cleaner transportation, dust management, industrial emission controls and public cooperation remain important. Festival-related measures must form part of a broader strategy for improving urban air quality.

Cleaner firecrackers alone cannot prevent severe pollution. Effective air-quality protection requires enforceable standards, reduced emissions and coordinated action against multiple pollution sources.

What will it take to restore peace in Manipur?

GS II

- **Ethnic conflict** can deepen when communities develop mistrust over identity, security and political representation. Violence may displace families, damage livelihoods and weaken everyday interactions between groups. Restoring order therefore requires addressing the social divisions that continue even after major clashes decline.
- Security measures can reduce immediate violence, but they cannot independently **rebuild trust** between communities. Restrictions on movement and continued separation may reinforce fear and isolation. People need safe opportunities to travel, return home and resume normal activities for reconciliation to become meaningful.
- **Political dialogue** is essential when communities disagree over representation, administrative arrangements and security guarantees. An inclusive process must allow affected groups to express concerns and negotiate solutions. Without credible participation, agreements may lack public acceptance and remain vulnerable to renewed tensions.
- Long-term peace requires accountable administration, effective law enforcement and restoration of essential services. Authorities must address displacement, support livelihoods and investigate violence fairly. Confidence can gradually return when communities experience **equal protection** and see practical improvements in everyday security.

Lasting peace in Manipur requires security, inclusive political dialogue, restored livelihoods and equal protection. Reducing violence is only the beginning of reconciliation.

Why don't higher interest rates always control inflation?

GS III

- Inflation measures the general increase in prices across the economy. Headline inflation includes food and fuel prices, while **core inflation** excludes these volatile components. When both measures rise, it can indicate that price pressures are spreading beyond temporary changes in individual commodities.
- The Reserve Bank of India uses monetary policy to influence borrowing costs and economic demand. Raising the **policy interest rate** can make loans more expensive, encouraging households and businesses to reduce borrowing and spending. Lower demand can gradually reduce pressure on prices.
- Interest-rate increases cannot directly resolve shortages caused by poor harvests, supply disruptions or higher imported fuel costs. These **supply-side pressures** may keep prices elevated even when borrowing becomes expensive. Monetary tightening can also slow investment and economic growth while attempting to control inflation.
- **Inflation expectations** influence how businesses set prices and how workers negotiate wages. If people expect prices to keep rising, their decisions can reinforce inflationary pressure. Central banks therefore consider future inflation risks, economic conditions and public expectations rather than responding only to the latest monthly figures.

Monetary policy can control demand-driven inflation, but persistent price pressures also require supply-side improvements. Interest-rate decisions must balance price stability with economic growth.